Teaching Dossier

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This is the short version of my teaching dossier.
Original documents and a long version are available at http://tammolossau.com/td

Teaching Dossier

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Teaching Statement

Teaching, to me, is the most important and the most rewarding part of working in academic philosophy: it allows me to make a real difference to the way students look at the world, whether they question assumptions of their own thinking, how they respond to opposing views, and to what extent they have the capability and courage to make a case for what they think. Even if philosophy had never made any progress as a discipline, it would be worth keeping a philosophy department around just because engaging with philosophy allows students to grow as thinkers and persons. I focus on that kind of growth in my teaching.

To do so, keeping all students actively engaged is key. I usually begin the semester by writing a controversial thesis on the board – such as "Stones and trees have souls just like humans and animals do." I then ask students to argue for or against that claim with their neighbor, which makes sure that everyone gets used to talking in class. Throughout the semester, I use a "debating club" format in which students are split up in teams to prepare making the case for some philosophical position. I find it especially useful to have students prepare a case for a position that is different from what they really think, because this often leads them to look at the same issue from a different angle. Formats like this also take the pressure of some students, who may be reluctant to contribute to a discussion if they feel uncertain about what position they ultimately agree with.

When I lecture, I like to keep it short and focus on supplying context for the readings, clarifying the main thesis of the reading and sometimes picking up on especially different passages. I then choose discussion questions that allow students to draw from the readings and be able to contribute things that were in the reading, but not in the lecture. Setting up discussions this way rewards students who have done the reading thoroughly and naturally leads to a more philosophical exchange. During the pandemic, half of my classes were synchronous forum discussions, combined with a taped half-hour lecture. This format worked extremely well: even though students were only required to post once, most of them left about 5 posts, and several students told me that those discussions were one of the highlights of their (academic) week. Because these discussions allowed for better structure and led to contributions even from the more introverted or less confident students, I want to maintain this as a tool for in-person teaching.

Perhaps the most important skill to take away from a philosophy course is the ability to make a careful and sophisticated argument for a position. Because of that, papers are the most important kind of formative assessment and (except for logic classes) deserve to be the main assignment. However, to help students succeed at this I find it useful to supplement these with assignments that help students prepare for such a paper. In my course on philosophy of religion, I split students up into "workshop groups" in which they were asked to peer-review proposals for their papers and give presentations on a paper not on the syllabus they read in preparation for their paper. Combined with feedback from me on their proposals and draft, this greatly improved the quality of the papers, and more importantly often gave students confidence to go about a project that does not just amount to defending or criticizing a class reading.

Formats like workshop groups that stretch throughout the semester, not-quite-serious debating clubs, or "live" online discussions have also helped me foster an inclusive environment in my classes. Under such conditions, it is easier for students to feel that their own perspective is as valid as that of their classmates, which in turn will help the class itself. The experience that has brought this point out clearest for me was my class on philosophy of religion, in which there were representatives of all the world's biggest religions, including a former Taoist priest and a Mormon a few years past his missionary work, but also a few atheists. I structured the class around the question "what is religion?", which (contrary to a course that focuses on the question "does God exist?") allowed for the inclusion of non-Western thinkers on the syllabus – I will present a poster as part of the Teaching Hub at the Eastern APA's conference in January 2022. A few weeks into the semester, students began to be more willing to share their own views about what was essential to religion, which we were able to the contrast between Matthew Tindal's rationalist picture and Friedrich Schleiermacher's view that religion is a feeling. That sort of safe environment also led to a willingness to engage with views completely contrary to their own: the more religious students could debate the Marxist arguments for religion being an obstacle to progress, and the atheists could debate Swami Vivekananda's ideas about religious experience.

I have self-taught five courses at Johns Hopkins (and I am scheduled to teach another in Spring 2022), and I have worked as a teaching assistant in over a dozen courses, both at Hopkins and in Göttingen. Over the course of that time, I have always strived to improve, which is why I completed the Johns Hopkins Teaching Academy over the 2019/2020 academic year. In 2020 I was also a finalist for the Excellence in Teaching Awards at the Krieger School for Arts and Sciences. Teaching has always felt like the part of my work that makes a real difference and that I can be proud of, and I therefore see it at the heart of my academic activities.

Summary of Student Evaluations

COURSES TAUGHT AS PRIMARY INSTRUCTOR

Overall course quality
(1=Poor, 2=Weak, 3=satisfactory, 4=Good, 5=Excellent)

Course	*Semester*	*N*	*Course Quality*
Themes from the Philosophy of Religion	Fall 2020	15	**4.67**
Do we have souls? If so, what are they?	Winter 2020	7	**4.57**
Wittgenstein and the Limits of Our World	Winter 2019	6	**4.83**
Belief in God	Winter 2018	21	**3.86**
Philosophical Intuitions	Summer 2017	3	**4.00**

COURSES TAUGHT AS TEACHING ASSISTANT

Overall effectiveness, compared to other instructors you have had
(1=Poor, 2=Weak, 3=satisfactory, 4=Good, 5=Excellent)

Course	*Semester*	*N*	*Teaching Effectiveness*
Introduction to Formal Logic	Spring 2021	6	**4.83**
Introduction to Metaphysics	Spring 2020	12	**4.67**
Philosophic Classics	Fall 2019	14	**4.93**
Introduction to Formal Logic	Spring 2019	9	**4.33**
Formal Methods of Philosophy	Fall 2018	10	**4.70**
Introduction to Formal Logic	Spring 2018	10	**5.00**
Philosophical Problems	Fall 2017	20	**4.30**

Sample Course: Themes from the Philosophy of Religion (Fall 2020)

Syllabus

Course Description

Religion has always been a contested and extensively debated topic throughout the history of philosophy, and the topics from the philosophy of religion are still relevant today. In this course, we will look at several of those topics: what is religion? Do we have reason to believe or not believe in God? How does God relate to the world (or are there many Gods)? How can we understand religious practice? And what role (if any) should religion play in our society?

Course Objectives

The primary goal of this course is to gain an understanding of some of the most influential views and arguments from the philosophy of religion and the historical trajectory that shaped them. You should be able to explain and contextualize the views expressed in the readings in depth and to critically discuss them and clearly advocate your own opinion. More broadly, this will also help building several reasoning and expression skills in general: engaging with complex readings and closely analyzing them will improve your ability to read carefully and attend to detail as well as to weigh the different readings. Critical assessment of the arguments expressed in those readings will allow you to learn thinking and expressing yourself clearly and precisely both in conversation and in writing.

Class Format

Due to the ongoing pandemic, this class will run entirely online, although it will follow the original schedule. The modalities of the course will look like this:
Readings for each week will usually be assigned to be read by Tuesday.

- I will pre-record a lecture of about 30 minutes and post it by Tuesday morning. The idea is for you to watch that lecture at 10:30 on Tuesdays. (I will link to these videos on the MS Teams site.)
- Following that until 11:45, we will have an online discussion on the Microsoft Teams site. I will provide discussion questions in the lecture and will be participating in the discussion on Teams. You are welcome to continue the discussion after class ends, or post earlier if you have a scheduling conflict.
- On Thursdays, we will be meeting on Zoom and discussing that weeks content further. Typically, this will involve group work using breakout rooms.

Student Assessment

Grading for this course consists of four components:

- A preliminary paper (20%)
- Preparatory stages of the final paper (20%)
- The final paper (40%)
- Weekly posts and participation (20%)

The preliminary paper is a 4-5 page paper to be written early in the class. I will assign a choice of topics (which will relate to the different conceptions of religion) and provide a guide on how to write such a paper within the first few weeks. The idea is for you to write that paper over a

period of two weeks, mainly as a way of allowing you to get a sense of what you will need to do in the final paper.

The main project in this class is your final paper, which should be 12-15 pages long and cover a topic that you choose yourself. This paper should come close to an academic research paper and should go beyond what we are covering in class. In particular, it should cover content and literature that is not covered in our regular meetings, and it should contain some line of argumentation that goes deeper than or is different from what we talked about in class. I'm happy to help you in finding a topic and identifying relevant literature.

To help you write that paper, you will need to submit preparatory stages of your paper throughout the semester. After the preliminary paper, you will need to declare which section of the class you would like to write your final paper about. I will assign you to a workshop group based on that interest, and I will set up a MS Teams chat for each group. You are encouraged to group chat about your papers in that group. As preparatory work, you will need to do the following things:

- Write a proposal for your paper that describes its thesis, structure, and the literature you want to read (5%)
- Provide feedback on the proposals of your workshop group (5%)
- Give a short literature report to your workshop group about a text or paper you read for your final paper (5%)
- Submit a draft of your final paper at least two weeks before the due date (5%)

Finally, this class has a participation component which covers two aspects:

- Your discussion posts on Teams (10%): you are expected to post at least one short comment or question every week. The comment has to be relevant and thought-out, but it is sufficient for it to be 2-3 sentences long. I will only count comments being posted on the relevant Tuesday (so you can't post a bunch of comments towards the end of the semester).
- Your participation in Zoom meetings and group workshops (10%): you are expected to actively participate in the class meetings, both in group work and in class discussions. (I recognize that the former is difficult for me to assess, but I will give you the benefit of the doubt.) Failing to regularly attend these meeting (including being late / leaving early) or ignoring group workshop discussions counts against this part of your grade.
  See the section below for my policies on missed meetings or posts.

Because of the special circumstances, the university has decided to make S/U grading the default option for this class. Here are the specific Krieger School policies concerning that:

- You can switch to a regular letter grade for any number of courses you like. Please check with the registrar's office for the relevant deadlines.
- If you take this class as S/U, it will still count towards all degree requirements that require a graded class, including those that require at least a C.
- The course requirements described above (and the policies described below) *do not change* if you take this class as S/U. The university has set up the system in such a way that I do not know which of you are choosing to receive a letter grade, and I have been told to not ask you about your grading preferences. I will therefore act on the assumption that any of you may be needing a letter grade.

Course Policies

- Attendance is required. You can miss up to a total of four Zoom classes or discussion posts without any penalty (e.g. you could miss two Teams discussion posts and two Zoom classes). Beyond that, you can only miss classes/posts with a valid excuse. If you miss more than four classes without a valid excuse, there will be a penalty on your overall grade. (If you have a letter from the disability office that exempts you from attendance requirements, you can ignore this paragraph.)
- Late assignments: assignments are always due at midnight at the end of the day specified on the course schedule. I will allow a "grace period" until 4am, but after that the assignment counts as late. For every day an assignment is late, there will be a deduction of 5% from the grade of that assignment. However, if the assignment is late more than 5 days, it will simply be graded 0%.
- Zoom etiquette: when attending Zoom classes, please open Zoom 2 minutes before the start time, so we are able to begin on time. While we are in the main meeting, please keep your video on, but your audio muted unless you would like to talk. In breakout rooms, please unmute yourself. Please use the "raise hand" button and other buttons in the "Participants" menu of Zoom, and feel free to post questions in the chat (but please don't have a side discussion in the chat).
- Covid-related accommodations: I realize that this is a difficult time for many of you, and that some of you may have additional obligations or restrictions in the way they can do academic work. Please alert me of any ways in which these circumstances inhibit your participation in this class – I will try to provide accommodations for that. (Some examples of such restrictions: being in a different time zone, having to take care of your siblings, having an unsteady internet connection, …)
- Finally, some of you may feel strongly about the topic of this course – either because you are religious yourself, or perhaps because you have a relation to some form of harm that has been done in the name of religion. This makes it important for us to work together to create a friendly environment in which our different perspectives can coexist. It also presents an opportunity for us to learn to voice opinions and productive criticism to someone who disagrees with us, and to be receptive to such statements and respond to them well.

Disability Accommodations

If you are a student with a disability or believe that you might have a disability that requires special accommodations, please contact Student Disability Services to obtain a letter from a specialist: Garland 385; (410) 516 4720; studentdisabilityservices@jhu.edu. The terms of these letters will be honored. (Please make sure I actually received the letter. If I did not write you a quick email acknowledging that I got it, I probably did not get it.)

Academic Integrity

The strength of the university depends on academic and personal integrity. In this course, you must be honest and truthful. Ethical violations include cheating on exams, plagiarism, reuse of assignments, improper use of the internet and electronic devices, unauthorized collaboration, alteration of graded assignments, forgery and falsification, lying, facilitating academic dishonesty, and unfair competition. Report any violations you witness to the instructor. You may consult the associate dean of students and/or the chairman of the Ethics Board beforehand. See the guide on "Academic Ethics for Undergraduates" at https://studentaffairs.jhu.edu/policies-guidelines/undergrad-ethics/ for more information.

Course Schedule
Detailed references are at the end of the syllabus.

Day	Topic	Readings	Notes
Sep 1 (Zoom)	Introduction		
I. Conceptions of Religion *What is religion? Is it a system of beliefs (and what kinds of beliefs)? Or is it a feeling?*			
Sep 3 (Panopto /Teams)	Natural religion	Tindal	
Sep 8 (Panopto / Teams)	Religion as moral belief / Religion as a feeling of absolute dependence	Kant, Schleiermacher	
Sep 10 (Zoom)			
II. Does God exist? *Can we prove or disprove the existence of God? And if not, do we still have reason to believe one way or the other?*			
Sep 15 (Panopto / Teams)	The Ontological Argument / The Cosmological Argument	Anselm, Gaunilo, Thomas	Preliminary Paper assigned
Sep 17 (Zoom)			
Sep 22 (Panopto / Teams)	The Argument from Design / Belief based on miracles?	Hume (Dialogues + Enquiry)	
Sep 24 (Zoom)			
Sep 29 (Panopto / Teams)	The Problem of Evil	Leibniz, Plantinga, Mackie	
Oct 1 (Zoom)			
Oct 6 (Panopto / Teams)	Pascal's Wager / The Will to Believe	Pascal, James	
Oct 8 (Zoom)			Preliminary Paper due
Oct 13 (Panopto / Teams)	Religion without belief? / Review session	Mackie	
Oct 15 (Zoom)	Review / workshop meeting		
III. God's relation to the world *Are things good because God approves of them, or is it the other way around? Are we free in our actions if God can foresee our choices? Is God in space and time or outside of it?*			
Oct 20 (Panopto / Teams)	Foreknowledge and freedom / God and space/time	Zagzebski, Boethius, Descartes	

Oct 22	*– Fall Break –*		
Oct 27 (Panopto / Teams)	God and morality / Pantheism	Plato, Spinoza	
Oct 29 (Zoom)			
IV. Religious Practice and Experience *What is prayer, and is it justified? What other kinds of religious experience and practice are there in Buddhism and Hinduism?*			
Nov 3 (Panopto / Teams)	Buddhism and emptiness / Yoga	Nagarjuna, Vivekananda	Election Day – you have the option of posting on Nov 4.
Nov 5 (Zoom)			Presentation session 1
Nov 10 (Panopto / Teams)	Prayer / Review session	Thomas, Of Prayer	Presentation session 2
Nov 12 (Zoom)	Review / workshop meeting		Presentation on Taoism + presentation session 3 PROPOSAL DUE
V. Religion and Society *Does religion have a place in our society? Can someone be religious and also be a good scientist? How is religion different from, say, political ideologies?*			
Nov 17 (Panopto / Teams)	Marxism and Religion / Secularism	MacIntyre, Habermas	
Nov 19 (Zoom)			Presentation session 4 REVIEWS DUE (11/22)
– Thanksgiving Break –			
Dec 1 (Panopto / Teams)	Religion and Science / Is religion Special?	Gould, Brownlee	
Dec 3 (Zoom)			DRAFT DUE
Dec 8 (Zoom)	Review / workshop meeting		
Dec 15	DUE DATE FINAL PAPER		

<u>Readings</u>
Here are the full citations of the readings, listed in the order of the course schedule. Readings will be made available via Blackboard.

Tindal, Matthew (1730). *Christianity as Old as the Creation*. Garland Publishing 1978. – Chapters 1+2.

Kant, Immanuel (1788). *Critique of Practical Reason*. Translated by Mary Gregor. Cambridge University Press 2015.– Book II, Ch. 2, sec. 5 ("The Existence of God as a Postulate of Pure Practical Reason").
Schleiermacher, Friedrich Daniel Ernst (1799). *On Religion: Speeches to Its Cultured Despisers*. Transl. by Richard Crouter. Cambridge University Press 1988. – Second speech, section B ("The Locus of Religion").
Anselm of Canterbury (1077/1078). *Proslogion*. In id., Major Works. Translated by M.J. Charlesworth. Oxford University Press. – Chapters 2-5.
Gaunilo of Marmoutiers (no date). *Pro Insipentie* (On Behalf of the Fool). Ibid.
Plantinga, Alvin (1969). *God Freedom and Evil*. Eerdmans. – Part II (c) ("The Ontological Argument").
Thomas Aquinas (1274). *Summa Theologiae I 1-13*. Translated by Brian Shanley. Hackett 2006. – Pars I, Quaestio 2.
Hume, David (1770). *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*. Ed. by Dorothy Coleman. Cambridge University Press 2007. – Pt. 3, par. 1-10 (pp. 29-32) and pt. 7-8 (pp. 52-62).
Hume, David (1748). *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*. Hackett 1977. – Section 10.
Leibniz, Gottfried Wilhelm (1710). *Theodicy: Essays on the Goodness of God, the freedom of Man, and the Origin of Evil*. Transl. by E.M. Huggard. Routledge 1951. – Appendix 1 ("Summary of the Controversy, Reduced to Formal Arguments").
Plantinga, op. cit. – Part I (a), sections 4-8 (pp. 29-55).
Mackie, John (1983). *The Miracle of Theism*. Oxford University Press. – Ch. 9, sections (d)-(f).
Pascal, Blaise (1670). *Pensées*. Transl. by John Warrington. Dent 1932. – Sec. 3, par 233 ("Infinity – Nothingness").
James, William (1898). The Will to Believe. In id., *The Will to Believe and other essays in the popular philosophy* (pp. 1-31). Dover 1956.
Mackie, John (op. cit.). – Ch. 12 ("Religion without belief?")
Plato (no date). Eutyphro. Transl. by G.M.A. Grube. In: John Cooper (ed.), *Plato: Complete Works* (pp. 1-16). Hackett 1997.
Zagzebski, Linda (1997). Foreknowledge and human freedom. In: Philip Quinn and Charles Taliaferro (eds.), *A Companion to Philosophy of Religion* (pp. 291-298). Blackwell.
Boethius (around 524). *The Consolation of Philosophy*. Transl. by David Slavitt. Harvard University Press 2008. – Book V, section VI.
Descartes, René (1644). *The Principles of Philosophy*. Transl. by John Cottingham. In id., The Philosophical Writings of Descartes. Cambridge University Press 1985. – Part One, par. 24-27.
Spinoza, Baruch de (1677). *Ethics, Demonstrated in Geometrical Order*. Transl. by T.S. Eliot. Princeton University Press 2020. – Book I, up until (including) proposition 16.
Thomas Aquinas (1274). *Summa Theologiae II-II*. Translated by the Fathers of the English Dominican Province. Christian Classics Ethereal Library. Available online at https://www.ccel.org/ccel/aquinas/summa.html. – Quaestio 83 ("Of Prayer").
Nagarjuna (ca. 150). *Nagarjuna's Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*. Transl. and commentary by Jay Garfield. Oxford University Press 1995. – Ch. 24 ("An Analysis of the Noble Truths") + commentary on that chapter.
Vivekananda, Swami (1896). *Raja Yoga*. Celephais Press 2003. – Book 1, chapters I and VIII.
MacIntyre, A. (1968). Marxism and Religion. In id., *Marxism and Christianity*. University of Notre Dame Press.
Habermas, Jürgen (2006). Religion in the Public Sphere. *European Journal of Philosophy* 14: 1-25.
Gould, Stephen Jay (1997). Nonoverlapping Magisteria. *Natural History* 106: 16-22.
Brownlee, Kimberley (2017). Is religious conviction special? In: Cecile Laborde and Aurelia Bardon (eds.): *Religion in Liberal Political Philosophy* (pp. 309-320). Oxford University Press.

Student Evaluations

NUMERICAL RESULTS

Question	*Course Mean (N=15)*	*School Mean*	*Department Mean*
5: excellent – 1: poor			
The overall quality of this course is:	**4.67**	4.22	4.10
The instructor's teaching effectiveness is:	**4.67**	4.29	4.20
The intellectual challenge of this course is:	**4.73**	4.29	4.29
Feedback on my work for this course is useful: (5: agree strongly – 1: disagree strongly):	**4.73**	4.04	4.21
Compared to other Hopkins courses at this level, the workload for this course is: (5: much heavier – 1: much lighter)	**3.27**	3.20	3.12
– custom questions –			
Suppose this class were to run again in a post-pandemic world. What would you think about the following format as a student: the Tuesday classes stay the way they were, i.e. they consist of a taped lecture and an online discussion on Teams. Only the Thursday classes are taught in-person. Would you prefer this hybrid setup to a fully in-person class? (5: prefer hybrid – 1: prefer full in-person)	**3.60**		
Were the small tasks that were meant to prepare you for the final paper helpful to you, or did you just think of them as additional work? (5: tasks were very helpful – 1: tasks were not helpful)	**4.40**		

STUDENT COMMENTS

What are the best aspects of this course?

• The material is interesting, and the professor is clearly knowledgeable in the field. The professor was also understanding and willing to work with students to make the course the best possible experience for everyone.
• The readings we do are great because they allow us to read and be familiar firsthand with the big philosophers who wrote on the topic. The discussions are also really fun and engaging, and allow us to fully explore and internalize the conceptual learning. Even though the readings can be hard, the instructor does a great job at explaining them and making sure everyone understands.
• I absolutely loved the structure of course, materials, feed back, professor. I do not think I could have had a better experience.
• Literally everything. The readings were well-selected, the asynchronous and synchronous lectures were well-structured, and feedback on our work was really helpful. This course prepared me so well for upper-level philosophy courses, and I'll take the things I learned with me going forward. The instructor was also one of the best I've ever had at this university. We need more professors like Tammo!
• weekly teams discussions were always amazing and insightful. The weekly readings were also great.
• The live class discussions.
• I loved the material and I think Tammo adjusted to remote really well.
• - The hybrid format worked SUPER well! See more comments below.
- Lively discussion from all members of the class (which may not have been able to happen in the same way if the class was fully in-person)
- Respect for everyone's own beliefs, which is important in a religion class
- Just really excellent content
• -Professor is Friendly and approachable
-Teams worked very well for discussion
-A lot of great student interaction and debate
• Content was very interesting, instructor gave great feedback, pre-discussion videos were very helpful in clearing up any misunderstandings of the texts. Really liked how Tammo helped space out steps in writing our final papers, it allowed for a lot more student-professor contact and guidance early on. Tammo was also very understanding of students' time! I really appreciated how we seldom ran over time, and that there was no expectation to do additional work outside of class time (other than our essays/assignments).
• Class discussion is insightful. Professor is good at explaining text and provides great feedback. Very personable and genuinely cares. He will go out of his way to help.
• EVERYTHING is awesome about this course! Tammo did an excellent job getting students engaged in online discussions and ZOOM lecture and class discussions. I really enjoyed the group/team work efforts inn discussions of papers
• Loved the freedom to digest and present different philosophy perspectives/arguments as if the readings we read were truly ideas that we had to argue for. It helped us more practically learn about those picture ideas. Loved the mix of online discussion and synchronous Zoom meeting: the multi-modes of communication helped enrich our learning.

What are the worst aspects of this course?

• The course is a mix of philosophy majors and people who are only interested in the subject, and occasionally this separation presents challenges for students who are not experts in methods of philosophical thought or argument.
• Perhaps the fact that readings can be old, so difficult to understand. But this is true for most of philosophy, and not the class' fault. Again, the instructor is great at making sure everyone understands.
• n/a
• Nothing at all. Philosophy of religion isn't something I'm particularly interested in — it kind of just fulfilled a requirement for me, but the excellent teaching of the course made it valuable.
• N/A
• The readings are good but sometimes too long.
• I wish this class would have been writing intensive because I thought it was and I felt like there was enough writing for it to be.
• - Nearly exclusive dependence on Teams — would have been helpful to have class announcements sent through email
• N/A
• Lots of reading and self studying. Term paper is long and is stressful.
• N/A
• There's only 2 big graded papers! Ouchie.

What would most improve this class?

• More instruction on background/central themes to the readings, for students who aren't as familiar with philosophical documents.
• I think the class is already quite nice as is.
• n/a
• Not much, it was already really excellent. I like how halfway through the semester we shortened the discussion section on our Thursday meetings and did more with workshop groups, definitely keep that up.
• N/A
• Not sure. There is a good balance of learning and critical application of ideas.
• I think the class being in person would have been more fun. But it was fun regardless.
• - Another smaller assignment in the middle of the semester, so that so much of the grading does not rest on only the two papers
• Maybe have a list of additional readings and things to look into based on discussions. Would love to explore a few things more outside of the class
• I would recommend setting a syllabus that can be adhered to for the whole semester. Perhaps provide more peer and instructor review sessions.
• N/A
• The first paper should count less, or be given room for revision, so that we can all get back into the swing of things or at least see what the professor is looking for.

What should prospective students know about this course before enrolling? (You may comment on any aspect of this course such as assumed background, readings, grading systems, and so on.)

• A background is philosophy would be useful, and a confidence with reading/writing a philosophical text.
• You can take and enjoy this course with no background in philosophy.

• Great class Great professor, I wish he would teach more courses.
• The instructor for this course is amazing, and no one could provide a better introduction to the philosophy of religion. Having read a few modern philosophers beforehand would be helpful, but you'll be fine if you haven't.
• Fair and thoughtful professor and willing to be flexible in times of need. Also an amazing instructor who handled the material maturely without appearing biased or favored in one direction. An amazing and absolutely fun class, would recommend!
• Don't be afraid to bring your own religious perspectives to your thinking. It broadens other's understanding of the overall discussion.
• It will probe a lot of the most interesting questions about religion and what religion is. It supplies a really good framework for thinking about these things.
• - Some background in either religion and/or philosophy is helpful (I would not take this as your first philosophy class)
• Engage in discussion, do the readings, but don't stress too much if some of them are hard to understand.
• Understanding of philosophy and religion is extremely important although not required. Writing experience is needed to write a solid paper.
• Prepare to dive into unique, diverse literature! Leave your judgement and prejudice outside the door. Be ready to ask questions and tackle the material with analysis and sincere thinking!
• The topics in this class (at least when I took it) were more Christian themed heavy, but we do touch on other religions for a few weeks. But you can write about any religion you want when you write your papers. People of a lot of different religious backgrounds took this class though, and that was cool!

Suppose this class were to run again in a post-pandemic world. What would you think about the following format as a student: the Tuesday classes stay the way they were, i.e. they consist of a taped lecture and an online discussion on Teams. Only the Thursday classes are taught in-person. Would you prefer this hybrid setup to a fully in-person class?[1]

• I feel like throwing around raw ideas on Tuesday and then going over the discussion on Thursday and really engaging with each other is really nice, and I think it could work perfectly in hybrid system.
• I really loved having the asynchronous aspect when we were online, but if the course were fully in-person I'm not sure. If we were meeting for classes fully in person, I'd also be okay with having the discussion in person, but I think the Microsoft Teams format was really accommodating.
• I actually really loved the hybrid format, and feel that this class was improved over what its in-person format would have looked like. Multiple Teams discussions allowed for me to read my classmates' responses, consider them, and come back to them later. I was able to link to other sources to further enhance the discussion. Starting Thursday classes with a recap of the Teams convos was useful, too. This was a great idea and one that I hope will carry over into other classes.
• Teams had great discussions that we could pace ourselves and was one of my favorite aspects of the course
• I'm an introvert and online discussions were much easier for me to participate in. It would be important to make sure that those who are not as comfortable talking out loud have space/opportunities to do so!
• I like this! One benefit of the hybrid is that students have time to cook and make a meal while attending the lecture online. Or they have more flexibility that fits their schedule to listen to the

1 This and the following question were added by me to the survey.

lecture and still be heavily involved in the discussions.• As I commented above: "loved the mix of online discussion and synchronous Zoom meeting: the multi-modes of communication helped enrich our learning." I think people express themselves in different ways and there are pluses and minuses to each mode of communication.

Were the small tasks that were meant to prepare you for the final paper helpful to you, or did you just think of them as additional work?

• Helped keep me on track, and it was helpful to get feedback on every step so that I knew I was in the right direction.
• So, so helpful. Most instructors don't help us think through our papers like this, but I'm so glad I was able to experience this before going to upper level courses. I think the feedback really improved my writing not only in this course, but in general.
• Ensuring we needed to hand in a draft no doubt made procrastination more difficult and likely led to a better final product.
• I did think of the tasks as additional work as I was doing them. But when finals season rolled around, they were immensely helpful. I started my final paper not from scratch, but with advice from three classmates and the professor. I think that without these small tasks, I would not have constructed as strong of a paper. In the end, I'm very glad we did these tasks, and I would recommend doing them again.
• It got me thinking about the topic earlier than I would have, but probably interfered with the workflow I would've liked for the final paper (would've finished certain things and paced myself in relation to my other classes better than when I had to worry about small tasks)
• VERY helpful to reasonably process through each step getting to the final paper.